DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Why Must Evil Grow Before It Ends?

Daat Tevunot §161-166

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §161-166 (beginning of section 9) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Monday 16 October 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Where we are

We begin section 9 on page 542. The Rabbi recapped the book: section 1, the purpose of creation; 2, God's unity; 3, the concealment of that unity; 4, body and soul as revelation and concealment; 5, how evil came to be; 6, man's interaction with evil; 7, emanations acting on the world; 8, the force that keeps the world in existence.

Section 9 is really the last section of the book's big picture of good and bad. It tries to explain why and how bad things happen to good people, and it describes the tikkun haklali, the guiding light that permeates existence and through which HaKadosh Barukh Hu is always bringing the world to its conclusion. Section 10 is a collection of separate topics.

A warning first: do not play God

Before anything else, the Rabbi warned that we must never say "this happened because of that". He had heard of a rabbi telling students that the victims of the massacre died because of a specific sin. "Could be, could be not. We've got no idea." The Ramhal will say that not even the greatest prophet knows what is caused by what, unless God tells him explicitly, as when the prophets were told that a disaster came for breaking Shabbat or oppressing the orphan.

Two subjects: the hidden mode and mazal

The Sekhel says: until now I explained reward and punishment, how good brings light and bad brings darkness. Now we come to a completely different mode, a hidden one that directs the world to its perfection. After that we will discuss mazal: what does luck mean, if HaKadosh Barukh Hu controls the world?

The Rabbi pointed out the paradox we met before. The hidden mode is the light of the Yihud Hashem that brings the world to its end. The revealed mode, reward and punishment, is what we see, yet it does not by itself bring about the revelation of the Yihud.

§161-165: the Neshamah's question and the limits of knowledge

The Neshamah asks the question that troubles it most: why do some righteous people prosper and some suffer? The Sekhel answers that the specific reason for each individual is beyond us. The Neshamah protests: then why raise it? The Sekhel defends himself. There is a limit to how far we can understand, but what we cannot explain will not damage our faith. The specific details are not needed. What is needed for clear faith, a general and broad explanation, we can give, and that is sufficient. "Hashem didn't give us things that we're not able to understand without emunah."

§166: why reward and punishment is not enough

The Sekhel now explains. If God only wanted to reward the good and punish the bad, the system of sections 7 and 8 would be enough. But God wants the end to be only good, with no bad left at all. Reward and punishment can only balance things out; it cannot eradicate evil.

The Rabbi gave an analogy from the news. After a massacre, one could punish the perpetrators proportionately and stop there. That would be balance, but it would not eradicate the evil. Or think of a doctor. If a patient has lost his appetite, you could give him something to increase it, but if the cause is a serious illness, you have to treat the cause.

So to bring about a complete tikkun, God must go to the root of evil. This was always the plan; God does not change His mind. The root is what we learned at the start: evil exists so that God's oneness can be revealed. The world must look as if there are many powers and no one God, so that in the end it is shown that there is only one power, and all the bad was actually good.

Darkness makes the light visible

The more God hides His face and lets evil spread, to the furthest limit short of destroying the world, the stronger the revelation of His unity when He rectifies it. A candle lit in a bright room is hardly noticed. In a pitch black room, with no street lamps outside, everyone sees it.

Strict reward and punishment keeps everything constantly in check: do wrong and you are punished, do very wrong and you perish. Evil never proliferates, but its root is never removed. For evil to reach its maximum, God must completely conceal Himself, as the verse says, "truth will be missing." That complete concealment comes before the complete tikkun.

Why the righteous suffer in this mode

In this mode God does not take into account how much good a person has done. As long as evil is allowed to spread, good people will suffer too. This is not because they deserve it, but because the hidden plan requires it. They will be fully compensated when the good is revealed: "Make us glad according to the days You afflicted us." At such a time, "the wise man keeps silent."

More than that, the chaos itself is part of it: not only are the righteous not protected, but the wicked prosper, while upright people are afflicted.

The Rabbi applied this cautiously to events: the world seems more barbaric than ever, when people can openly support a massacre of Jews. Perhaps it is part of the general tikkun moving towards its end. "I'm not saying either way. It's a possibility."

Does our behaviour still matter?

A participant asked: if we, the Jewish people, were doing much better, would all this darkness still be needed? The Rabbi went back to basics: why God created the world, our perfection; how, through the revelation of His unity. There are two ways to reveal it. The greatest is that everyone does good, withstanding temptation as Adam and Havah failed to do with the serpent's "you will be like God". That depends on humanity as a whole. Since that has not happened, there is individual responsibility, and also God running everything to its end. "The more we do in mode one, the less has to happen in mode two."

The reward of the righteous who suffer

On page 550 the Ramhal concludes. In the hidden mode the righteous are not saved by their merit, not because they did wrong, but in order to bring the final tikkun through them. This is good for them. Under reward and punishment alone, all a saddik could achieve is his own personal reward, "very selfish": I do good, I am rewarded, I perfect myself. But now that they suffer for the sake of the world, their reward will be as partners in the rectification of the whole world, in uprooting the evil.

Summary

- No one, not even a prophet unless told explicitly, can say why a particular event happened.
- What is needed for faith is the general principle, not the reasons for each case.
- Reward and punishment balance good and evil but cannot uproot evil; for that, evil must be allowed to spread, short of destroying the world, and then be overturned.
- In that time of darkness the righteous may suffer and the wicked prosper, regardless of merit.
- The righteous who suffer this way are compensated, and share in the reward of rectifying the whole world. Next: mazal.

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